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Be Strong and Courageous

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Be Strong and Courageous

Today's Reading: John 18:12-18

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"Simon Peter followed Jesus, and so did another disciple. Since that disciple was known to the high priest, he entered with Jesus into the court of the high priest, but Peter stood outside at the door. So the other disciple, who was known to the high priest, went out and spoke to the servant girl who kept watch at the door, and brought Peter in."

* * * * *

All the other disciples had fled except two—Peter, and another one who was unnamed. He was John, the author of this Gospel. Once again he was deferential about revealing his identity, and because of this, we know who he was.

Peter and John followed Jesus to "the court of the high priest," an enclosed space with no roof, meaning one could look up and see the sky. Peter stayed outside the gate, while John entered. He was known to the high priest and was able to enter.

There was a servant girl guarding the courtyard. John went to her and vouched for Peter, and she allowed him to enter.

Peter and John's courage should be noted. All the other disciples had fled. By contrast, John and Peter desired to be faithful to the Lord. They had followed the entourage that had arrested him because they feared something awful might happen to him.

In the face of enormous adversity, they chose to follow Jesus. They were very courageous.

What is courage? It is not being ignorant about the future and yet still moving forward. Rather, true courage is clearly knowing what awaits you but still choosing to move ahead. It's unflinchingly staring the enemy in the face while not knowing what the eventual outcome may be.

Jesus is always looking for courageous followers—disciples who might not know what’s awaiting them but are still willing to march into hell for a heavenly cause. He needs people who will be unabashed witnesses for him—both in word and deed. He needs fearless helpers who will act to advance the Father’s kingdom on earth.

Yes, Peter would go on to deny the Lord. But at least he was in the courtyard. At least he hadn’t run away as the others had. John and Peter resisted cowardice. They went inside the courtyard. They knew doing this was dangerous, but still they followed their Master.

Emulate Peter and John. Be strong and courageous for Jesus. Do not panic or be afraid of those who may criticize or threaten you. What can they do to you? Jesus will guard you from all sides. He won’t fail or abandon you. He will fight for you and give you victory.

Jesus will arm you with his strength. He will go ahead of you in the battle. The battle belongs to him. In fact, he has already won the battle!

Jesus knows you by name. You are his. Knowing these truths should give you enormous confidence. You can be very bold.

He will make your way perfect. He is your sun and your shield. He is your shelter and refuge. He is your strong tower. He watches over every area of your life. He will protect you from danger.

Why should you tremble?

Trust him with all your heart.

[from *“Hearing the Voice of God”* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]